

GUEST LECTURE at TUM

Modern B2B Marketing

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Management



Technology



Data science

Today's Session

B2B and B2C Marketing

Why B2B differs from B2C — and how both changed in 25 years

Buying groups & journey

Personas become committees; content must build consensus

Strategy choices

ABM, value narrative, and SAP-style customer value journey

Data science engine

CRM, automation, AI, martech, partners, and measurement

Synthesis

Checklist for a B2B software marketing strategy

Discussion and Q&A

LEARNING PROMISE

You will leave with a strategy lens for B2B software marketing, not a checklist of tactics.

Is B2B marketing less exciting than B2C?

Who here thinks B2B marketing is less creative than B2C?

B2C

One person
one credit card
one moment of choice

Different kind of creativity:

B2B

Six people
three systems
two budgets
one business case
one procurement process

align stakeholders, integrate with IT, satisfy finance, and reduce risk



Poll: What makes enterprise software marketing hard?

Choose the option you think creates the biggest strategic challenge.



A

Knowing the customer

The “customer” is not one person; it is a buying group.



B

Proving value

The product is expensive, risky, and often invisible until adopted.



C

Aligning revenue teams

Marketing, sales, partners, and customer success co-create demand.



D

Using data well

Signals are fragmented across anonymous, account, and lifecycle data.

Prompt: argue for your vote in one sentence

The thesis: B2B marketing is confidence engineering

**Marketing does not just create demand.
It reduces decision risk.**

Risk ↓	Clear business case, social proof, adoption path
Consensus ↑	Shared language across finance, IT, users, and executives
Value proof ↑	Quantified outcomes and credible evidence
Pipeline quality ↑	Fewer stalled deals; better-fit opportunities



Why B2B software is a different marketing problem

	Consumer marketing logic	Enterprise software logic
Buyer	Individual / household	Buying committee + influencers
Value	Benefit, emotion, convenience	Business outcome + quantified ROI
Product	Finished experience	Configurable system + implementation
Place	Retail / digital channel	Sales, partners, marketplaces, customer success
Promotion	Preference and conversion	Consensus, trust, and risk reduction
Research	Surveys, experiments, panels	Account data, intent signals, usage, sales feedback

Translation challenge: keep the marketing fundamentals, change the unit of analysis.

B2C evolved: from mass media to algorithmic relationships

	Around 2000 — THEN		Today — NOW
Channels	TV, print, radio, basic websites		Mobile-first, social, influencers, marketplaces, apps
Role of digital	Experimental banners, basic SEO, bulk email		Core growth engine: performance, social commerce, apps
Data & targeting	Broad segments, delayed feedback		Behavioral data, micro-segmentation, real-time optimization
Relationship	One-way broadcast		Two-way and community-driven: UGC, reviews, DMs

B2B evolved: from brochures to account intelligence

	Around 2000 — THEN		Today — NOW
Go-to-market	Sales-led, trade shows, cold calls, printed collateral		Digital + sales orchestration: content, webinars, social selling
Buyer journey	Vendor-driven, early sales contact		Buyer-driven, heavy self-research, shortlist before sales
Targeting	Broad segments by industry and size		ABM: named accounts, intent data, stakeholder-level targeting
Data & tools	Basic CRM, spreadsheets, disconnected systems		Automation, integrated CRM, AI scoring, chatbots
Convergence: B2B buyers increasingly expect B2C-like digital experiences — self-service, transparency, and fast answers.			

The “customer” is a buying group, not a persona

13

internal stakeholders
in the typical buying decision

9

external influencers
shape confidence and risk

Average enterprise software decisions combine different jobs-to-be-done:



What marketing must do:

- Make the business case shareable
- Equip champions for internal selling
- Reduce risk with proof, demos and peer signals
- Coordinate digital, sales and partner touchpoints

From the 4Ps to four enterprise software system decisions



PRODUCT

What business capability are we helping the customer build?

Platform, integration, roadmap, adoption



PRICE

How do we align value capture with buyer risk?

Subscription, consumption, bundles, proof of value



PLACE

Which routes make buying and deploying easier?

Direct sales, partners, cloud marketplaces, CS



PROMOTION

How do we create confidence across the committee?

Thought leadership, proof, events, executive content

The strategic question shifts from “What do we sell?” to “How do we make organizational change easier to buy?”

AI does not replace the 4Ps — it sits inside each P

	Without AI	With AI
Product	Roadmap from surveys + sales feedback	Usage analytics; in-product recommendations + next-best actions
Price	Static lists + manual discounts	Price corridors, discount guidance + deal scoring
Place	Fixed channels + manual territory planning	Route accounts direct / partner / digital; prioritize coverage
Promotion	Broad segments, batch email + manual optimization	Predictive targeting, personalization at scale + automated testing

Important caveats

AI speeds decisions — but it can scale wrong/bad assumptions.

Data quality + bias

Clean CRM + product data are non-negotiable.

Human nuance

AI can miss politics and strategic exceptions.

Over-automation

Personalization can become spam.

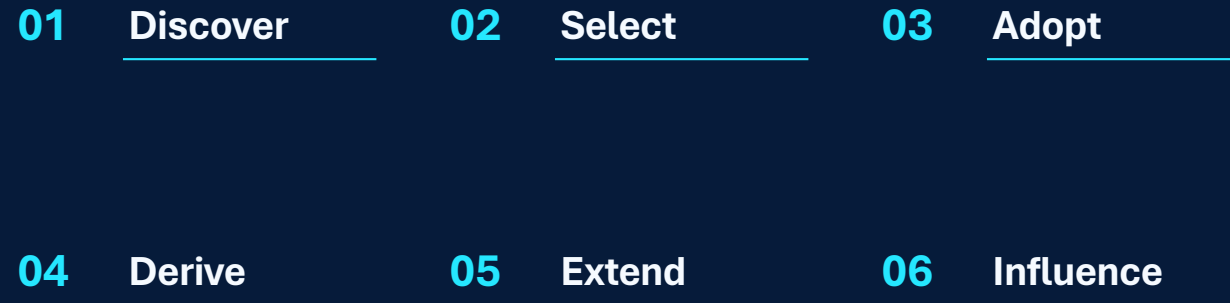
Strategy leads

Humans set positioning, segments and ethics.

AI makes the 4Ps faster and more data-driven — if marketers own strategy and ethics.

SAP example: from funnel thinking to Customer Value Journey

SAP describes a lifecycle engagement model emphasizing customer value beyond the purchase.



STRATEGIC SHIFT

The market offer is not only software. It is a path to measurable customer outcomes.

Partners and customer success become part of marketing strategy.

Exercise: map a buying committee in three minutes

SCENARIO

A university wants an analytics platform to improve research administration, funding insights, and compliance reporting.

DELIVERABLE

One mini-map:

Role → Concern → Proof

- 1 Name five buying-group roles.**
- 2 Write one concern each role will have.**
- 3 Write one proof point each role would need.**

Bonus:

Who could block the deal even if they are not a user?

Ideal Customer Profile (ICP) – the base layer of B2B segmentation

DEFINITION

An Ideal Customer Profile (ICP) is a description of the type of company that gets the most value from your solution and, in return, is most valuable to you.

Typical ICP criteria

- 01 Firmographics**
industry, company size, region, revenue
- 02 Technographics**
ERP/CRM stack, cloud maturity
- 03 Business model & situation**
B2B/B2C, growth stage, key challenges
- 04 Buying behavior**
deal size, sales cycle, propensity to adopt

ICP vs buyer persona

ICP = ideal company

Which accounts should we pursue?

Buyer personas

= ideal people inside that company

IT lead, CFO, business owner, procurement, etc.

Exercise: define an ICP in 5 minutes

BRIEF SCENARIO

You are launching a new B2B SaaS product: an AI-powered analytics add-on for ERP systems (e.g., SAP).

DELIVERABLE

One sentence:

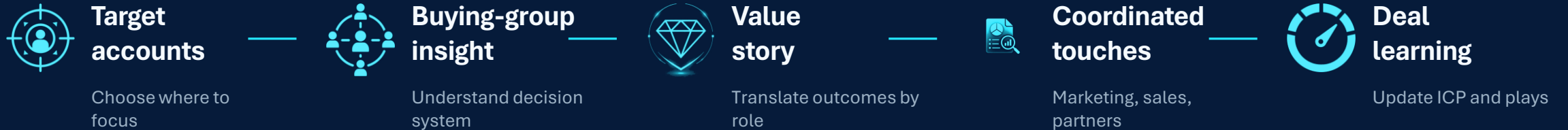
“Our ICP is...”

Key fit signals:

- Industry focus
- Company size
- Region
- Tech stack
- Key business problem

- 1** In groups of 3–4, draft an ICP for this product.
- 2** Decide on: industry focus, company size, region, tech stack, key business problem.
- 3** Be ready to share in one sentence: “Our ICP is...”

Account-based marketing: a coordinated operating model



ABM flips the question:

Not: “How many leads can we generate?”

But: “Which accounts should change, and how can we help the buying group decide?”

SAP example: from broad segments to account intelligence

Then

Broad campaigns to large segments

Limited visibility into specific accounts

Revenue teams worked from partial account context

Now

Named strategic account lists

Intent data + stakeholder insight

One-to-one plays aligned with sales and partners

MARKETING MOVE: Top accounts get custom journeys — messaging, proof, events, partner motion, and sales plays are coordinated.



Traditional ABM vs AI-powered ABM

Dimension	Traditional ABM	AI-powered ABM
Account selection	Manual lists from firmographics + sales input	Scoring from intent, behavior + conversion history
Research & insights	Human account research; hard to scale	Surfaces topics, products + account signals
Personalization	Manual plays for a few top accounts	Variations by industry, role + stage
Campaign execution	Fixed plays; periodic reporting	Real-time targeting, bids + content optimization
Measurement	Manual activity + pipeline reports	Pattern detection + next-action recommendations

AI doesn't change ABM's goal — it makes account choice, insight and personalization scalable.

What makes B2B campaigns work — or fail?

Works well when...

- 1 Problem framing is role-specific
- 2 Sales alignment turns interest into pipeline
- 3 Right accounts, channels, and proof are connected

Fails often when...

- 1 Messaging is generic or feature-heavy
- 2 Marketing and sales operate in silos
- 3 Audience, problem, or channel is wrong

Failures are often organizational — weak alignment, wrong target, or unclear value — not simply “bad creative.”

Content that sells complex change: make the internal argument easier



CFO

Will the economics work?

ROI calculator | Payback model



CIO / IT

Will this fit and be secure?

Architecture brief | Security proof



Business leader

Will the outcome matter?

Value narrative | Peer case story



Users

Will my work get easier?

Demo path | Adoption playbook

**Good B2B content is not “more information.”
It is decision support for a buying group.**

Technology: the B2B marketer's toolbox

B2B marketing uses technology to “see” account behavior and coordinate revenue teams.

CRM + lead management

Shared record of accounts, contacts, pipeline, and sales activity

Marketing automation

Email, nurture, event follow-up, scoring, and handoffs

Data integration

Connect website, events, email, product usage, partners, and sales

AI + analytics

Lead scoring, intent detection, next-best action, and experimentation



Data science turns marketing into a learning system



The hard part is not building a score. It is deciding what action a score should trigger — and how teams learn when the score is wrong.

AI and martech change the workflow — not the strategic burden

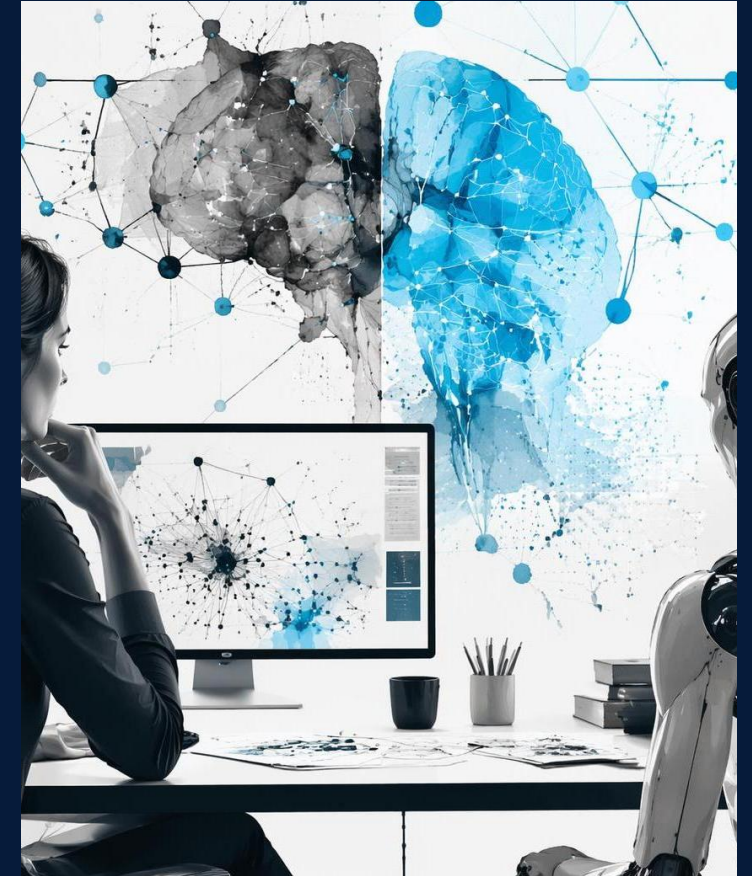
What changes

1. Research velocity
2. Content variants
3. Personalization at scale
4. Signal detection
5. Experimentation loops

What must not change

1. Clear customer strategy
2. Credible value proof
3. Consent and data governance
4. Sales and partner alignment
5. Human judgment for risky decisions

**AI amplifies strategy quality.
It also amplifies strategic confusion.**



Partner ecosystems are not a channel detail — they are part of the offer

Software vendor

Roadmap, platform, brand

Systems integrator

Transformation delivery

Enterprise customer

Hyperscaler

Cloud infrastructure

ISV / app partner

Extensions and industry apps

Customer success

Adoption and value realization



Five strategic trade-offs B2B software marketers manage

Scale



Relevance

Speed



Confidence

Automation



Trust

Category thought leadership



Product proof

Ecosystem reach



Brand control

**Strategic maturity = knowing which side to emphasize for which ICP,
buying stage, and growth objective.**

How B2B marketing teams turn strategy into operating rhythm

Product marketing

Positioning | Value proof | Launch narrative

Demand / ABM

Account plays | Campaigns | Coverage

Digital + data

Intent signals | Personalization | Experiments

Partner marketing

Co-sell motions | Marketplace | Ecosystem proof

Sales + customer success

Field feedback | Adoption story | Expansion signals

ALIGNMENT RITUALS

Campaign council | Account review | Message testing | Experiment backlog | Win/loss learning

Should a software company gate all high-value content?

Take a side — then switch sides.

Gate it

- Capture intent
- Qualify accounts
- Route to sales
- Measure demand

Ungate it

- Reduce friction
- Build trust
- Reach hidden buyers
- Support internal sharing

Right Question: Which content should build confidence before the buyer is willing to reveal themselves?

What this means for your marketing career

- | | | |
|----|----------------------------------|--|
| 01 | Strategic diagnosis | Define ICP, problem, value, and right-to-win |
| 02 | Analytical fluency | Interpret data, test assumptions, question metrics |
| 03 | Technical curiosity | Understand platforms, AI, integration, data flows |
| 04 | Commercial storytelling | Translate features into business outcomes |
| 05 | Stakeholder orchestration | Align sales, product, partners, and customers |

Useful mindset: be the person who connects customer reality, technology potential, and business impact.

A 7-point checklist for B2B software marketing strategy

- | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | Which customer problem is urgent enough to fund? | 2 | Which accounts and buying groups are we prioritizing? |
| 3 | What value narrative can travel internally? | 4 | Which proof reduces perceived risk? |
| 5 | Which digital and human interactions should we combine? | 6 | Which partners make buying and adopting easier? |
| 7 | Which metrics show decision confidence and learning? | | |

If you can answer these, you have a strategy — not just a campaign plan.

The future of B2B marketing is not choosing between marketing, technology, and data science — it is connecting them into one growth system.

Reduce risk. Build consensus. Prove value. Learn faster.

Thank you — now let's discuss.

